

Story1

The pool was nearly empty at this hour. I swam leisurely laps, enjoying the solitude. After a few laps, I lifted myself out of the water to rest by the edge of the pool.

A figure caught my eye at the other end of the pool. A man was pacing by the diving board, phone in hand, deep in conversation. Something about the way he walked, the way he gestured with his free hand as he spoke, struck me as familiar. I squinted, trying to place him. It couldn't be. After all these years, was it really—?

It was Q, my old college friend. We had been inseparable for the four years of undergrad, bonding over late night debates that lasted into the early hours of dawn, spontaneous road trips to nearby towns on the weekends, and optimistic dreams of changing the world and making a difference. Q seemed destined for greatness. His charm, quick wit and brilliance left the rest of us in awe. On graduation day, I was convinced our friendship would stand the test of time, lasting for decades to come. He was pragmatic but also deeply compassionate, with a strong sense of justice and desire to help others. In many ways, Q's idealism and belief in humanity's fundamental goodness had shaped my own view of the world during those formative years. I remembered the long conversations we would have, discussing politics, philosophy and our hopes for changing the world. Q was always so idealistic and believed one person could make a difference. His energy and passion were infectious, and I found my own dreams and ambitions expanding just by being in his presence.

Yet we had drifted apart, as people often do. The fantasy of maintaining life-long friendships is much harder than people anticipate or expect. To truly stay friends requires constant effort, investment, honest communication and commitment from both parties. We had exchanged somewhat annual holiday cards and social media greetings, but that was the extent of our communication over the past two decades.

Over those years, Q had pursued a dazzling career in the high stakes world of finance in New York City, working his way up at breakneck speed to become a managing director at a prestigious investment banking firm. His star continued to rise meteorically in the competitive world of Wall Street. My own path was slower and quieter in Silicon Valley at a tech startup. The years slipped by silently without much progress in rekindling our long-distance friendship. We were now like two ships passing in the night, our lives fragmented into separate chapters.

I sank lower in my seat, not wanting Q to notice me. I suddenly felt extremely anxious about our unexpected encounter and wasn't ready for an awkward reunion. Although we shared memories of a deep college friendship, we were now little more than strangers. Yet I felt a thrilling kind of excitement at this chance to secretly observe him from afar, undetected. What would I discover about the man Q had become over the years?

Q paced in agitation, running an agitated hand through his graying hair. His brows were knit, and as he turned I caught a glimpse of his face. Age and immense responsibility had left their mark; faint lines now etched his forehead and framed the edges of his tired eyes. The immense stresses and crushing workload of his high-power job were taking both a visible physical and emotional toll, aging him beyond his years. He seemed to have aged decades in the span of a few years. The idealistic, bright-eyed Q I once knew seemed to have vanished, replaced by this weary and worn down version. I felt a pang of sadness, realizing how much he must have sacrificed to achieve such great success.

To achieve such heights of power and status demands immense sacrifice and often comes at a hefty price. Material comfort and lavish rewards are poor consolation for lost youth, health, relationships, ideals or purpose. I could only imagine the private anguish, self-doubt and staggering burdens that came with Q's lofty position. His commanding presence remained unchanged. He still exuded an air of confidence and authority, as of someone long accustomed to persuading and prevailing in high-pressure board rooms and shareholder meetings. But was there a hidden cost to maintaining this image of the self-assured corporate titan?

"I understand why you're upset, Q was saying. His tone was gentle yet firm, like one would speak to a distressed child. "But you have to trust my judgment on this. The restructuring plan is in the best interest of the company and our long-term strategy. Employee morale and productivity have been declining for too long following lackluster earnings reports. Significant changes must be made now to turn things around before the end of the fiscal year. I hope that in time you'll come to see why this difficult decision was the right one for the future of the firm.

A lengthy pause ensued. Even from a distance, I sensed this conversation was not going well. Q's initial composure seemed to be cracking, exposing the hidden turmoil and weariness he struggled to contain under the surface. His shoulders sagged under the immense weight of worry and exhaustion. I wondered what other troubles, uncertainties and regrets lay beneath the surface of his outwardly glamorous yet immensely stressful life. How much had he given up for a success that seemed to bring little joy or peace?

Q's jaw tightened. "No, that claim is unfair and completely inappropriate. I have never made an important decision without careful consideration of all possible consequences and outcomes. I would never intentionally damage our company or harm people's livelihoods. I have always respected your leadership and appreciated your counsel. There's no need for threats or attacks on my integrity. Let's remain civil and professional.

Q fell silent again, listening with a pained expression. He sighed heavily and for a moment seemed to shrink in stature as his usual confidence and dynamism temporarily deserted him, exposing his deepest vulnerabilities. In that unguarded moment, a wave of empathy washed over me. My heart ached for the private

suffering and self-doubt I glimpsed, realizing even the once infallible Q struggled at times under the crushing burden of immense responsibility and isolation that came with his lofty position.

The difficult call finally ended. Q remained unmoving for several long minutes, gazing at the pool with a distant look in his eyes. His shoulders were slumped under the weight of worry and exhaustion. I wondered what other troubles, uncertainties and regrets lay beneath the polished surface of his outwardly glamorous yet immensely stressful life as a high-powered Wall Street executive. How much of his humanity had he sacrificed for a hard-won success that seemed to bring little joy or peace?

Then Q straightened, rolled his shoulders back, and strode off with renewed purpose. His familiar aura of self-assurance and determination settled over him once more as he headed out of the pool area. But I had caught a fleeting glimpse of the private anguish and vulnerability behind the carefully constructed image of the self-confident corporate titan. My assumptions about Q's perfect and enviable life had been challenged today, reminding me that no one, not even the seemingly invulnerable Q, had life all figured out. We were all imperfect beings learning as we went, trying to navigate setbacks, self-doubts and regrets along the way.

I left the pool comforted, realizing I was not alone in that lifelong struggle. Our shared humanity still bound us, despite the distance between us. I hoped our paths might cross again someday, allowing us another chance to reconnect and rediscover the friendship we had once shared. But for now, I was grateful for this reminder that behind each stoic and self-assured facade lay a vulnerable human spirit, learning to rise and fall with each new challenge in life's uneven and difficult path. Even the most successful of lives was made of moments of private anguish and uncertainty, reminding us of our shared fallibility and need for compassion.

-----The End-----

Story2

I never thought I would see him again. Q, the guy who seemed to have it all figured out in college - the perfect grades, the popularity, the effortless charm. It was almost intimidating how flawless he was. We had been close friends back then, the kind that shared secrets and dreams late into the night, but life had taken us in different directions after graduation, and we had lost touch.

Fast forward a decade later, and there I was, lounging by the pool, trying to escape the suffocating heat of the city. I had chosen to visit this particular pool precisely because it was a hidden oasis, far away from the bustling crowds. I craved solitude, a momentary break from the constant demands of life. But fate had a different plan in store for me.

As I settled onto my poolside lounger, I let myself drift into a sense of calmness. The bright sun warmed my skin, and the sound of water lapping against the

pool's edges created a soothing melody. Closing my eyes, I allowed my mind to wander and reminisce about the past.

That's when I heard it - a familiar voice carrying over the sound of splashing water and laughter. Curiosity piqued, I opened my eyes and followed the voice to its source. And there he was, standing at the edge of the pool, talking to a woman I didn't recognize.

Q hadn't changed much over the years. His dark hair was a little thinner, a few lines had etched themselves around his eyes, but he still exuded that same confidence and magnetism that had made him so irresistible back in college.

Unable to resist the urge, I put on my sunglasses and positioned myself in a nearby shady spot, pretending to read a book while observing Q from afar. It wasn't long before I noticed something unusual. The woman approached Q with a serious expression on her face, and I could sense her frustration as she gestured animatedly.

Intrigued, I discreetly focused my attention on their conversation. It became apparent that the woman had some unresolved work-related issue with Q. She spoke passionately, her words filled with anger and disappointment. But instead of responding with his usual charisma, I saw something different in Q's face - vulnerability.

His usually perfect poise cracked, and for a moment, I caught a glimpse of the challenges he faced beyond the facade. I saw a man who was struggling to find the right words, trying to salvage the situation but failing miserably. Q stumbled through his explanations, fumbling over his words, and I couldn't help feel a sense of empathy for him.

The woman's anger slowly dissipated, replaced by a mixture of confusion and compassion. She nodded sympathetically, their conversation taking on a more subdued tone. Q's voice became softer, almost apologetic, and I found myself caught between the desire to approach him and the fear of interrupting a private moment.

Eventually, the woman let out a deep sigh and offered Q a hesitant smile. They exchanged a few more words before parting ways. The weight of their conversation hung in the air as Q turned his gaze toward the pool, seemingly lost in thought.

My curiosity got the better of me, and I decided to approach Q. As I made my way towards him, a mix of nervousness and anticipation filled my chest. Would he remember me? Would he dismiss our college friendship as a distant memory?

When I finally stood before him, doubt gripped me. But as Q looked up and our eyes met, a glimmer of recognition flashed across his face. A smile crept onto his lips, as if a missing piece of his puzzle had just been found. Without any hesitation, he stretched out his arms, and we embraced as if no time had passed at all.

We spent the rest of the day catching up, sharing stories of triumphs and failures, successes and disappointments. It turned out, life hadn't been as flawless for Q as it had seemed. Beneath his impeccable exterior, he had faced struggles, learned valuable lessons, and grown into a more genuine version of himself.

As the sun began to set and the poolside lights flickered on, I couldn't help but marvel at how life's unpredictable twists had brought us back together. Our friendship, once buried in the depths of college memories, had rekindled in the most unexpected of places - a humble poolside oasis that had become the backdrop for a long-overdue reunion.

In that moment, I realized that flaws and difficulties were what made us human. And while it was easy to envy the seemingly flawless, it was in our vulnerabilities that we truly connected and found solace. Q taught me that perfection was nothing more than an illusion, and it was in our shared imperfections that true friendship flourished.

As I watched Q dive into the shimmering water, his carefree laughter echoing through the night, I couldn't help but appreciate the beauty of this serendipitous encounter. Our paths had crossed again, reminding me that sometimes, even in a seemingly flawless world, it was the unexpected hiccups that brought us closer together.

Days turned into weeks, and weeks turned into months as Q and I rekindled our friendship. We spent countless hours together, reminiscing about our college days, laughter erupting from deep within our souls. We explored new places, tried new adventures, and created a lifetime's worth of memories in that short period of time.

Q continued to surprise me. Beneath his polished exterior, he revealed his quirks and vulnerabilities. We delved into the challenges he faced throughout the years, the moments he struggled, the times he doubted his own abilities. It was in those moments that our bond grew stronger, as we realized how much we could rely on each other.

As the seasons changed, our friendship blossomed, intertwining our lives in the most unexpected ways. We became each other's steady rocks, offering support during times of uncertainty. We were there to celebrate each other's successes, and to lift each other up during moments of defeat.

Q encouraged me to rekindle my old passions, to chase after the dreams I had almost forgotten. With his unwavering support, I took risks, explored different career paths, and embraced new opportunities. He reminded me of the person I used to be, the person I could still become.

In turn, I became Q's confidant, someone he could turn to in times of need. Whether it was a shoulder to cry on or a sounding board for his ideas, I was there. Our friendship became a shelter from life's storms, a place where we could be vulnerable and find solace in each other's company.

As the years unfolded, Q and I faced the ups and downs of life side by side. We weathered storms and celebrated triumphs, always there for each other no matter what. Our bond grew stronger with each passing day, an unbreakable connection forged through the tests of time.

And so, as I look back on that fateful day by the pool, I am grateful for the turning of events that led us back to each other. In a world that often seems driven by appearances and perfection, it was our shared imperfections that brought us together, that made our friendship enduring and meaningful.

Q taught me that life's twists and turns may take us on different paths, but true friendship can withstand the test of time. The poolside oasis was more than just a chance encounter; it was a reminder that even in the most unexpected of places, friendship can bloom and flourish, transforming our lives in the process.

As I think back to that day, I am filled with gratitude for the rekindling of our treasured friendship. Q, with his flaws and vulnerabilities, reminded me that true connection lies not in perfection, but in the understanding and acceptance of each other's imperfect selves. And so, armed with this newfound wisdom, we face the future together, ready to embrace whatever comes our way.

-----The End-----

Story3

Just behind the kingdom that failed ran a nice little river. It was a clear, lovely stream, and many fish lived in it. Weeds grew there, too, and the fish ate the weeds. The fish didn't care whether or not the kingdom had failed, of course. Whether it was a kingdom or a republic made no difference to them. They didn't vote or pay taxes. Makes no difference to us, they figured.

I washed my feet in the stream. A short soak in the icy-cold water turned them red. From the stream, you could see the walls and the tower of the castle in the kingdom that failed. The two-colored flag still flew from the tower, fluttering in the breeze. Everyone passing along the riverbanks would see the flag and say, "Hey, look at that. It's the flag of the kingdom that failed.

Q and I are friends—or should I say, were friends in college. It's been more than ten years since the two of us did anything that friends do. Which is why I use the past tense. Anyhow, we were friends.

Whenever I try to tell anyone about Q—to describe him as a person—I feel totally helpless. I've never been very good at explaining anything, but, even taking that into account, it's a special challenge to try to explain Q to someone. And when I do try I'm overcome by a deep, deep sense of despair.

Let me make this as simple as I can.

Q and I are the same age, but he's about five hundred and seventy times more handsome. He has a nice personality, too. He's never pushy or boastful, and he never gets angry if someone accidentally causes a problem for him. "Oh, well,

he'll say. "I've done the same thing myself. But, in fact, I've never heard of him doing anything bad to anyone. He was well brought up, too. His father was a doctor who had his own clinic on the island of Shikoku, which meant that Q never wanted for pocket money. Not that he was extravagant with it. He was a smart dresser and also an impressive athlete, who'd played interscholastic tennis in high school. He enjoyed swimming and went to the pool at least twice a week. Politically, he was a moderate liberal. His grades, if not outstanding, were at least good. He almost never studied for exams, but he never failed a course. He really listened to the lectures.

He was surprisingly talented on the piano, and he owned a lot of Bill Evans and Mozart records. His favorite writers tended to be French—Balzac and Maupassant. Sometimes he'd read a novel by Kenzaburo Oe or another writer. His critiques were always right on the mark.

He was popular with women, naturally enough. But he was not one of those "anyone he can get his hands on type of guys. He had a steady girlfriend, a pretty sophomore from one of the fancy women's colleges. They went out every Sunday. Anyhow, that was the Q I knew in college. In short, he was a character without flaws.

Back then, Q lived in the apartment next door to mine. What with lending salt or borrowing salad dressing, we got to be friends, and soon we were at each other's places all the time, listening to records, drinking beer. Once, my girlfriend and I drove out to the Kamakura shore with Q and his girlfriend. We were very comfortable together. Then, during the summer break of my senior year, I moved out, and that was that.

The next time I saw Q, almost a decade had gone by. I was reading a book by a swanky hotel pool near the Akasaka district. Q was sitting in the deck chair next to mine, and beside him was a beautiful long-legged woman in a bikini.

I knew right away that it was Q. He was as handsome as ever, and now, just over thirty, he evinced a certain dignity that he hadn't had before. Young women walking by gave him a quick once-over.

He didn't notice me sitting next to him. I'm a fairly ordinary-looking guy, and I was wearing sunglasses. I wasn't sure whether I should talk to him, but in the end I decided not to. He and the woman were deep in conversation, and I hesitated to interrupt them. Besides, there wasn't a lot that he and I could have talked about. "I lent you salt, remember? "Hey, that's right, and I borrowed a bottle of salad dressing. We would have run out of topics quickly. So I kept my mouth shut and stuck to my book.

Still, I couldn't help overhearing what Q and his pretty companion were saying to each other. It was a fairly complicated matter. I gave up trying to read and listened to them. "No way, the woman said. "You've got to be kidding.

"I know, I know, Q said. "I know exactly what you're saying. But you've got to see it my way, too. I'm not doing this because I want to. It was the guys

upstairs. I'm just telling you what they decided. So don't look at me that way.

"Yeah, right, she said.

Q let out a sigh.

Let me summarize their long conversation—filling in a good deal by way of imagination, of course. Q seemed to be now a director at a TV station or some such place, and the woman was a moderately well-known singer or actress. She was being let go from a project because of some sort of trouble or scandal she had become involved in, or maybe just because her popularity had declined. The job of informing her had been left to Q, who was the person most directly responsible for day-to-day operations. I don't know much about the entertainment industry, so I can't be sure of the finer points, but I don't think I'm too far off over all.

Judging from what I heard, Q was discharging his duty with genuine sincerity.

"We can't survive without sponsors, he said. "I don't have to tell you that—you know the business.

"So you're telling me that you don't have any responsibility or say in the matter?

"No, I'm not telling you that. But what I can do is really limited.

Their conversation took another turn into a dead-end street. She wanted to know just how much he had exerted himself on her behalf. He insisted that he had done everything he could, but he had no way to prove it, and she didn't believe him. I didn't really believe him, either. The more sincerely he tried to explain things, the more a fog of insincerity came to hang over everything. But it wasn't Q's fault. It wasn't anybody's fault. Which was why there was no way out of this conversation.

It appeared that the woman had always liked Q. I sensed that they had got along well until this business came up. Which probably only added to the woman's anger. In the end, though, she was the one who gave in.

"O.K., she said. "I've had it. Buy me a Coke, will you?

When he heard that, Q breathed a sigh of relief and went off to the drink stand. The woman put on her sunglasses and stared straight ahead. By this time, I had read the same line in my book a couple hundred times.

Soon, Q came back with two big paper cups. Handing one to the woman, he lowered himself into his deck chair. "Don't get too depressed about this, he said. "Any day now you'll— But, before he could finish, the woman threw her full cup at him. It caught him square in the face, and about a third of the Coca-Cola splashed onto me. Without a word, the woman stood up and, giving a little yank at the seat of her bikini, strode off without a backward glance. Q and I just sat there stunned for a good fifteen seconds. The people nearby were staring at us in shock.

Q was the first to regain his composure. "Sorry, he said and held a towel out to me.

"That's O.K., I answered. "I'll just take a shower.

Looking slightly annoyed, he drew the towel back and used it to dry himself.

"At least let me pay for the book, he said. It was true that my book was soaked. But it was just a cheap paperback, and not a very interesting one at that. Anyone who threw a Coke on it and prevented me from reading it was doing me a favor. He brightened up when I said that. He had the same great smile as always. Q left at that point, apologizing to me once more as he stood to go. He had never realized who I was.

-----The End-----

Story4

My college roommate, Quincy, or "Q" as everyone called him, always struck me as something of a miracle worker. For four long years, I watched him navigate his path, getting everything he wanted through a potent mix of charm, sheer natural ease, and that peculiar magnetism some people just seem to be born with. It was as though he had a direct line to the levers and gears on which the world operates and could effortlessly bend fortune to his will. From the moment we first met, I found myself inexplicably drawn to him, forever in his debt.

We were freshmen at a dismal urban college in the early nineties. Our freshmen dormitories were depressingly small and stacked to the height of eight stories, with all the charm of Soviet-bloc housing. Q was the esteemed president of our university's badminton club, an organization boasting everyone from furiously chain-smoking Malaysian girls to the privileged offspring of fifth-generation alums wearing thick socks and mahogany cable-knit sweaters. And even though I never once saw him pick up a racket, his commanding leadership seemed to imbue him with the kind of proxy athleticism that is far more useful than any success on the field or the court. For Q could charm us all without ever stooping so low as to actually play the sport he championed.

The strange thing was that only I seemed capable of seeing this. To everyone else, Q was the undisputed golden boy. He was undeniably luck-blessed, with a reputation for being kind and wise to boot. At the time, my more cynical instincts led me to conclude that it was just a great act that he put on, but as time passed, I realized that Q in private was much the same as the man who squired the daughters of university senators around the leaf-twined paths of the arboretum. He was the kind of person whose praises must be sung, or they'd go unacknowledged.

"Poor old Q!" people would say. "Nobody ever thanks him for anything." "Drinks on me!" was his irrepressible reply. And so, his legend grew.

We were not close, Q and I. I sometimes wonder if he was ever close to anyone. We would share my car on Sunday afternoons for errands, and once in a rare

moment of vulnerability, he showed me his mother's journals in his room. Beyond that, however, I didn't really know who he was. We lived separate lives, went our own ways and only met up at the dances his club constantly hosted: waltzes and celebratory balls, the dim lighting of which lent everyone the same air of soft romance as they glided across the scuffed gymnasium floor.

Ten years on, I had made a modest life for myself in bustling New York, while Q, like many of our classmates from years gone by, went west to sunny California. The sort of daily coincidence that holds friendships together easily unravels into silence once you no longer share the same spaces. Q and I found ourselves entangled in this familiar scenario, yet deep within my heart, I never felt that a distance had truly grown between us. He was often on my mind, like a specter that I could never entirely shake. It was almost as though I expected to see him on Manhattan's crowded streets one day, like on a random Saturday's shopping spree, I might turn around on Elizabeth Street and find him looking at me with a knowing smile, perched behind a table covered with pocketbooks.

It was in a quaint, wood-paneled room eighty miles east of the city that I first saw his name again. A cookery class was being held that weekend, and I was obliged to attend, thanks to an article I had penned on learning to cook in a country house. They had filed us one by one into a chic, bright room, the walls of which were dominated by posters illustrating the topography of wheat production in the era of Charlemagne.

"Your sections, everybody." The hostess, a stooped New Yorker in her seventies with prominent glasses and seven gold bracelets clanking and jingling, gestured to the name cards spread out across the desk in the front of the room.

I walked over obediently, and there, on a card for a set of four, was his name.

Q Rhodes.

One could have shared such a small dormitory room with anyone. Waking up every morning, I remembered lying on the lower bunk, my nose inches away from his supporting mattress.

There were matters of an alchemical nature in that room that cannot now bear thinking of shudderingly, those languid thoughts, so commonplace at the time, floating through my mind as my weary eyes closed at night: a cramped bunk room for two, my arms gripping a dove-grey blanket as I shivered in the biting cold, watching him across a single narrow aisle in which a pair of socks would be lucky to cross paths and not become hopelessly entangled.

I met Q's eyes and smiled warmly. He smiled back, as insincerely as I can ever remember smiling at another soul.

At lunchtime, fueled by a nostalgic curiosity, I found myself drawn to the pool area. I had brought a humble sandwich with me, housed within a small box that seals with a slight, airtight pop upon being opened. The poolside seating

area was tiled with mesmerizing blue oblongs the size of postage stamps, the patterns of which continued up the sturdy pillars supporting the roof overhead.

In the clear water, a wispy white cloud of chlorine billowed serenely out of a small cluster of pipes. I watched as the first of a flock of elderly women in bathing suits ambled over, followed by those who had learned to swim in the forties in decadent poolside cabanas accompanied by lavish wicker furniture and fragrant bougainvillea, and finally, the worldly men drawling out the final syllables of the high life.

Q, too, was there. He had changed into swim trunks and was reclining nonchalantly next to a seemingly smitten woman on a lounge, the pair of them sharing a plate of cheese and crudité under a gauzy parasol. They were idyllically ensconced in a world of overpriced suntan lotion and La Mer creams, and with a slight pang of envy, I felt as though Q had loosed the line that connected us, choosing to drift away with this nameless woman towards a sweet-scened, tantalizing summer dream.

I walked over, intending to say hello, but stopped short when I caught sight of the woman's rapt expression.

Q was talking, and she was listening with bated breath, her brow furrowed as his captivating words washed over her. He had the charm turned up to the highest setting, and it was working its undeniable magic. However, it was simultaneously abandoning him, too. He seemed to lose all grip on the conversation while the lady hung onto his every syllable, her whole body tense and attuned to every inflection, every suggestion, every glimpse of her own future he may have been unwittingly portraying.

If ever a man was showcasing his skill at eloquence, it was at the peak of his very own disaster. And Q's unique calamity was unfolding before me in slow motion. With each spoken word, he slipped under a little bit further, and my own hapless degradation was also etched into those fruitless, water-borne gestures of his. Q had always reassured me that I could never be an irredeemable lost cause, and now he was grappling for his own survival, his hands splayed out, his arms akimbo, his fingers tapping in a frenzy, attempting to keep time with the crumbling rhythm of his ultimate downfall.

I left him there, sprawled in the concrete semi-circle adjacent to the captivated lady, and walked away from the pool and a friendship built on shared experiences, such as the lazy afternoons spent deciphering each other's handwriting as we graded sophomore essays. After all those years, our friendship had become faint, weathered at the edges and drenched in the muted melancholy of time's relentless march, forever consigned to the past.

-----The End-----